words and the promise of some juice in the coming pages, are you reading this book?

Two reasons, I reckon. One: as frustrating as it's sometimes been to watch him play, Hersch has always delivered on that crucial contract between professional player and spectator. Your part is to pay the money; his part is to entertain you. With Hersch on the field, something is bound to happen. It could be a brilliant catch or a spectacular dive to cut off a certain four. It could be a couple of sixes in a brief but explosive innings. Or it could be 175 off 111 balls to pull off an impossible victory. From a value-for-money point of view, Herschelle Gibbs alone is worth the price of your ticket.

The second reason, though, is the more powerful one. It's the reason why there's an emotional bond between Hersch and his fans. It's the reason why messages of support pour in every time he finds himself in trouble. Thing is, Herschelle Gibbs, for all his flaws, has a massive heart. And throughout his life, Hersch has unashamedly worn it on his sleeve.

He's a genuinely friendly individual with the kind of demeanour that immediately puts anyone in his company at ease. I saw this first hand in India during the IPL. Hersch didn't just sign every autograph thrust at him or pose for every photo, but he did so in a way that made each of those fans feel like they had a real and personal interaction with him. Not many sports stars are able to do that.

What you see is what you get with Hersch. There's no hidden agenda, no sneaky manoeuvring for self gain. His ups and downs have been there for all to witness – from that beaming smile you see on the cover of this book to the scared and vulnerable man standing before the world during the King Commission. Whatever his faults may be, you can't help but like the guy.

And my thanks…

To end this author's note, I want to thank some important people. I can do this because I've recently read a bunch of other author's notes and I'm happy to report it's allowed. Obviously I've read a lot of books before, but no author's notes. Seriously, who the hell reads author's notes?

Firstly I have to thank my long-time friend, one-time colleague and fellow journalist Pieter Redelinghuys. The book was Piet's idea. He and I were having a few beers one night at The Shack, our local hangout, and Piet